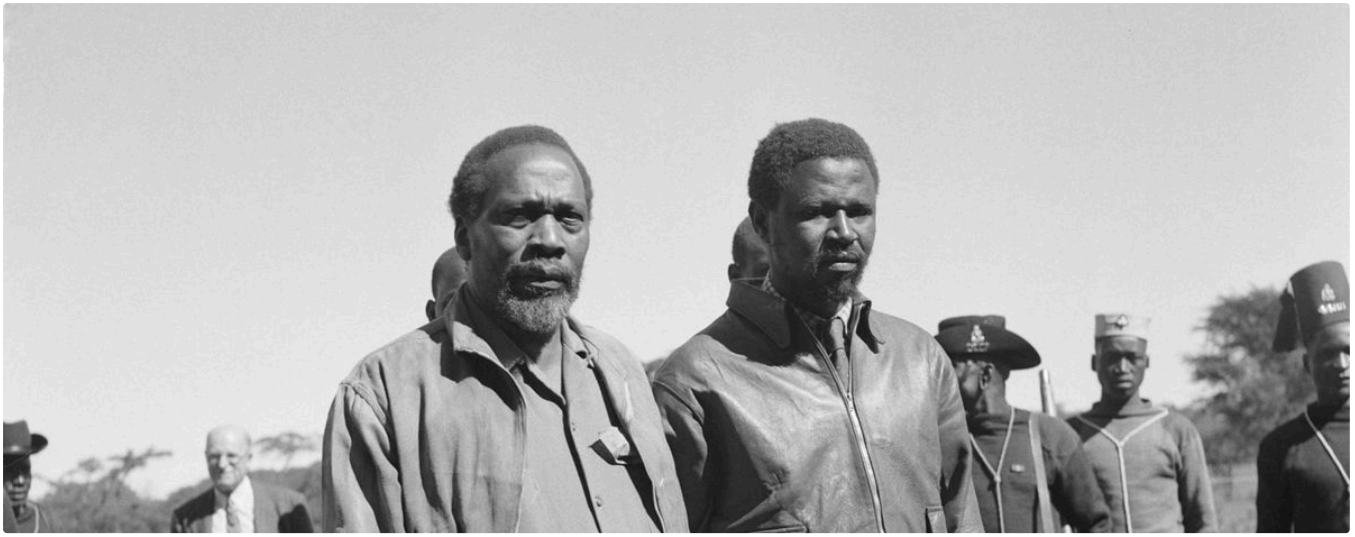
The Mau Mau Rebellion

Land, oaths and a state of emergency: how Kenya's forest fighters lost the war against Britain but won the argument that ended settler rule.



PHOTOGRAPH: Jomo Kenyatta (left, in the light jacket) under guard during the Kapenguria trial, December 1952. Britain jailed him as the alleged leader of Mau Mau. Eleven years later he became independent Kenya's first prime minister.

In the 1950s, thousands of Kenyans went into the forests of Mount Kenya and the Aberdare Range (Nyandarua) to fight the British colonial government. Many carried only homemade guns, spears and *pangas* (machetes). The British called the movement **Mau Mau**. Nobody agrees where that name came from, and the fighters themselves seldom used it. They called themselves the **Kenya Land and Freedom Army**, and the name stated their goal: *ithaka na wiyathi*, "land and freedom" in the Kikuyu language.

Britain won the fighting. By 1956 the forest armies had been broken up. But the rebellion, and the harsh methods used to crush it, destroyed the case for a Kenya ruled by white settlers. The State of Emergency ended in 1960. Kenya became independent on 12 December 1963, led by the same man Britain had imprisoned.

What you will learn. By the end of this booklet you should be able to:

- explain why land was the main cause of the rebellion;
- describe how earlier, peaceful African protest led to armed resistance;
- outline the main events of the Emergency, 1952–1960;
- explain why Mau Mau was also a civil war among Africans;
- describe the methods Britain used to defeat it, including detention and villagisation;
- explain how a military defeat helped lead to independence;
- discuss how Kenya and Britain remember the conflict today, and what historians still debate.

About the pictures: every picture is labelled PHOTOGRAPH or ILLUSTRATION. Photographs are real pictures from the period, or of places and memorials today. Where no usable photograph exists, an original painting was made for this document and is always labelled as an illustration, never as a photograph. **How to use this booklet:** each chapter ends with key terms and "Check your understanding" questions. Reference pages at the back give key people, a glossary, casualty figures, a full timeline and essay questions.

CHAPTER 1 · THE ROOTS

Land was at the heart of everything



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. A Kikuyu family works a small, crowded *shamba* (farm plot) on red earth, while a fenced European settler estate spreads across the fertile land beyond, under Mount Kenya. No single photograph shows this contrast, so it is painted.

Britain declared the East Africa Protectorate in 1895 and built the Uganda Railway across it, from the coast at Mombasa to Lake Victoria. To make the railway pay, the government encouraged European farmers to settle. The **Crown Lands Ordinance of 1902** let the government grant land to settlers. The **Crown Lands Ordinance of 1915** went further: it declared all land, including land where Africans lived, to be Crown land, so that Africans became tenants at the will of the Crown. In 1920 the territory became the **Colony of Kenya**.

Kenya's best farmland was reserved for Europeans: the cool, well-watered highlands around Mount Kenya and the Rift Valley, which came to be called the **"White Highlands"**. After the First World War a Soldier Settlement Scheme brought in more British ex-officers. The settlers numbered only a few thousand. The Kikuyu, Embu and Meru peoples, who lost the most land, numbered more than a million. Africans were confined to **"native reserves"**. In 1932–34 the Kenya Land Commission (the Carter Commission) looked at African land claims but rejected most of them, which left many Kikuyu bitter.

Inside the reserves, families divided already small plots among their sons until many holdings could no longer feed a household. Thousands of people became **squatters**: they lived and worked on European farms in return for a small plot, and could be evicted at any time. From the 1940s, settlers cut squatters' rights. Evictions, as at **Olenguruone** in 1946–50, drove families back into the overcrowded reserves with nothing.

Colonial rule also controlled daily life. Under the Native Registration Ordinance (1915, enforced from 1920), African men had to carry the **kipande**, an identity and work certificate kept in a metal case worn around the neck. Hut and poll taxes had to be paid in cash, which pushed men into wage labour on settler farms at deliberately low wages. Until the 1950s, Africans were not allowed to grow the most valuable cash crop, coffee. In Nairobi, Africans lived under curfews and pass rules in a city built on their labour.

> **Key idea:** land was not just one complaint among many. For the Kikuyu, land meant ancestry, a way of making a living and social status all at once. That is why a movement about land could win so much loyalty and demand so much sacrifice.

KEY TERMS

White Highlands	Fertile highland areas reserved by law for European settlers.
Native reserve	An area set aside for a particular African people, often overcrowded.
Squatter	An African family living and working on a settler farm in return for a plot of land.
Kipande	A compulsory identity and labour pass for African men.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Name two laws that took land from Africans, and say what each one did.
2. Why did the squatter system cause growing anger in the 1940s?

CHAPTER 2 · 1920–1945 NEW CHAPTER

Before Mau Mau: early African protest

Mau Mau did not appear from nowhere. It grew out of more than 25 years of peaceful protest that colonial rulers mostly ignored or suppressed.

Harry Thuku and the 1922 shooting

In 1921 a young telephone operator, **Harry Thuku**, formed the Young Kikuyu Association and then the East African Association. He campaigned against the kipande, high taxes, forced labour and the loss of land, and he tried to unite Africans across ethnic lines. In March 1922 the government arrested him. A large crowd gathered outside the police station in Nairobi to demand his release. A woman named **Mary Muthoni Nyanjiru** challenged the men to act, and the crowd pressed forward. Police and settlers opened fire. The official death toll was 21, but witnesses believed more were killed. Thuku was exiled to remote parts of northern Kenya for about nine years.

The Kikuyu Central Association

The **Kikuyu Central Association (KCA)**, founded in the mid-1920s, carried on the campaign. It focused on lost land and on the right of Kikuyu to run their own affairs. Its general secretary from 1928 was a young man then called Johnstone Kenyatta, later **Jomo Kenyatta**. In 1929 the KCA sent him to London to put Kikuyu land claims to the British government. He stayed in Europe for about 15 years, studied anthropology, and in 1938 published *Facing Mount Kenya*, a book defending Kikuyu culture.

Schools and churches of their own

In 1929–31 Protestant missions tried to stop female circumcision, an important Kikuyu initiation rite, and expelled church members who did not agree to give it up. Many Kikuyu saw this as an attack on their culture. They responded by setting up their own **independent schools and churches**, run by the Kikuyu Independent Schools Association and the Kikuyu Karing'a Education Association. In 1939 they opened a teachers' college at **Githunguri**, which Kenyatta later led. These schools spread political ideas, and the government closed them during the Emergency.

The Second World War

In 1940 the government banned the KCA and detained its leaders. Meanwhile tens of thousands of Kenyan Africans served in the British forces, in Ethiopia, Madagascar and Burma. These **ex-servicemen** (former *askari*) learned to handle weapons, saw that white soldiers could be beaten, and came home expecting

reward for their service. Instead they found no land, low wages and the same colour bar. Several later became forest commanders, including Waruhiu Itote ("General China"), who had fought in Burma.

> **Pattern to notice:** each peaceful method (petitions, associations, delegations to London, schools) was tried first. Each time the main demand, the return of land, was refused. This helps explain why a younger generation came to believe that only force would work.

KEY TERMS

KCA	Kikuyu Central Association: the main Kikuyu political body, 1920s–1940.
Askari	An African soldier or policeman serving under colonial command.
Colour bar	Rules and customs that separated people by race and kept Africans in lower positions.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Why did the 1929 circumcision controversy lead to independent schools and churches?
2. How did the Second World War change the attitudes of many African soldiers?

CHAPTER 3 · 1944–1952 · POLITICS CLOSES, THE OATH OPENS

A movement takes an oath



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. A night oathing ceremony in a village in central Kenya, early 1950s. Oathing was secret and no photographers were present, so no genuine photograph of a ceremony exists.

After the war, Africans tried open politics again. The **Kenya African Study Union**, founded in 1944, became the **Kenya African Union (KAU)** in 1946. It campaigned lawfully for land, better wages and African representation. Kenyatta returned from Britain in 1946 and became KAU president in 1947. KAU wrote petitions, held large meetings and sent delegations, but almost nothing changed. Settlers dominated the Legislative Council (LegCo), Kenya's law-making body, which in 1944 had only one nominated African member. London would not overrule the settlers.

Younger and more radical organisers lost patience. Many of them were trade unionists, ex-servicemen and evicted squatters. In Nairobi, trade unionists such as **Fred Kubai** and **Makhan Singh** built a strong labour movement. When both were arrested in 1950, Nairobi workers held a general strike lasting about nine days. Radicals gradually took over the Nairobi branch of KAU and formed a secret central committee, known as *Muhimu* ("important"), which directed the oathing campaign. A group of young men called the "Forty Group" (*Anake a 40*, after the 1940 age-set) helped enforce it. In August 1950 the government banned the secret society it called Mau Mau.

From the late 1940s, organisers in Nairobi and across the reserves gave **oaths**. The oath was based on Kikuyu tradition. It bound each person who took it to unity, secrecy and the recovery of the stolen land. A first "unity oath" was taken by ordinary supporters. A later, stronger "warrior" or *batuni* (platoon) oath bound fighters to kill if ordered. Taking an oath meant crossing a line: there was no easy way back. Some people took the oath willingly, and others were forced to.

Oathing spread very fast through the **passive wing**: farmers, market women, porters and clerks who would later feed, hide and fund the fighters. **Women** were central to this network. They carried food, messages, medicine and ammunition past checkpoints at great personal risk. Not everyone joined. Many Christians, especially members of the East African Revival, refused the oath on religious grounds, and some were killed for refusing. By 1952 the colonial government was facing not a small gang, as it claimed, but a mass movement it had failed to notice forming.

Pressure on officials and on chiefs loyal to the government turned violent. On **7 October 1952**, Senior Chief **Waruhiu wa Kung'u**, a leading supporter of the government, was shot dead near Nairobi. The government decided to strike first.

KEY TERMS

KAU	Kenya African Union: the main lawful African political party, 1944–1953.
Oath	A solemn, binding promise made in a ceremony; the basis of Mau Mau membership.
Passive wing	Civilian supporters who supplied, hid and funded the fighters.
LegCo	Legislative Council: the colony's law-making body, dominated by settlers.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Why did younger activists lose faith in KAU's peaceful methods?
2. Explain the role of the "passive wing", and of women in particular.

CHAPTER 4 · OCTOBER 1952

Emergency declared, leaders on trial



PHOTOGRAPH: Suspects rounded up in a mass screening sit in rows on a road under armed guard during the Emergency. *Screening* meant lining up and questioning whole communities, and it became the everyday face of the war for ordinary Kikuyu.

On **20 October 1952** the new Governor, **Sir Evelyn Baring**, declared a **State of Emergency**. A state of emergency gives a government special powers, such as arresting people without trial. That night, in **Operation Jock Scott**, police arrested Kenyatta and more than 150 other KAU leaders and suspected organisers. British troops were flown in. The Emergency lasted more than seven years, until January 1960,

much longer than the forest fighting itself. 20 October is now a public holiday in Kenya, Mashujaa (Heroes') Day.

The arrested leaders were tried at **Kapenguria**, a remote town chosen to keep the trial far from Nairobi's crowds and from journalists. The **Kapenguria Six** were Jomo Kenyatta, Bildad Kaggia, Fred Kubai, Kung'u Karumba, Paul Ngei and Achieng' Oneko. They were charged with managing Mau Mau. An international defence team, led by the British lawyer D. N. Pritt and including lawyers from Nigeria, Jamaica and India, defended them. Kenyatta said he had condemned violence and did not control the movement. The prosecution's main witness, Rawson Macharia, later swore (in 1958) that he had been bribed to give false evidence. In April 1953 all six were convicted and sentenced to seven years' hard labour, followed by restriction in remote areas. Oneko was cleared on appeal but was kept in detention anyway.

In one respect the trial achieved the opposite of what Britain wanted. It removed the moderate, public leaders and left the movement in the hands of the forest fighters, who answered to no politician. KAU was banned in June 1953 and lawful African politics was shut down, so the men and women in the forest became the main voice of the land demand.

Emergency laws were very harsh. The death penalty was extended to crimes such as giving an oath, carrying ammunition, or "consorting with" (being in the company of) armed fighters. Special Emergency courts heard cases quickly, often with little evidence.

> **1,090 people** were hanged by the colonial government for Emergency offences, the largest number of executions in any British colonial emergency. Thousands more received long prison sentences for oathing, "consorting" or carrying supplies.

KEY TERMS

State of Emergency	A legal declaration giving a government special powers in a crisis.
Screening	Mass questioning of civilians to find Mau Mau supporters, often violent.
Kapenguria Six	The six KAU leaders convicted in 1953 of managing Mau Mau.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Why do historians say the Kapenguria trial was unfair?
2. How did arresting the moderate leaders change the movement?

The forest war



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document. Women couriers bring baskets of food into a hidden camp in the bamboo forest of the Aberdares. The forest armies depended completely on these supply lines from the villages.

The fighters who went to the forests organised themselves as an army, with ranks, councils and rules. There were two main forces. In the **Aberdare Range** the best-known leader was **Dedan Kimathi**, a former teacher and clerk, together with **Stanley Mathenge**. On **Mount Kenya** the leading commander was **Waruhiu Itote**, known as **"General China"**. In August 1953 forest leaders met at Mwathe in the Aberdares and set up a Kenya Defence Council, with Kimathi as its head. In 1954 Kimathi formed the "Kenya Parliament" to give the movement a political leadership. There were serious quarrels, especially between Kimathi and Mathenge, about who should lead. Mathenge's fate after the war is still unknown.

Some women fought as well as carrying supplies. **Muthoni wa Kirima** rose to the rank of field marshal and stayed in the forest until after independence in 1963.

The fighters were desperately short of weapons. Many carried homemade guns built from pipe and wood, or rifles captured in raids on police posts and settler farms. Food, medicine and recruits all had to come from the passive wing in the reserves. That is why the government's counter-attack, described in Chapter 7, aimed to cut this supply line rather than only chase fighters through the trees.

The government side grew steadily stronger. **General Sir George Erskine** took command in June 1953. At the peak, about 10,000 British troops served alongside battalions of the **King's African Rifles**, the settler Kenya Regiment, more than 20,000 police and over 20,000 Kikuyu Home Guard. The forests were declared "prohibited areas" where anyone found could be shot. The RAF bombed the forests. Life there was brutal even without battle: cold rain at high altitude, hunger, disease and constant patrols by soldiers, trackers and aircraft.

From 1954 the tide turned. General China was wounded and captured in January 1954. He then took part in failed government attempts to arrange a mass surrender. Large sweeps such as **Operation Hammer** and **Operation First Flute** (1955) went through the forests. Offers of amnesty divided the remaining groups. **Pseudo-gangs**, made up of captured fighters who had changed sides and led by British officers such as Ian Henderson, hunted their former comrades.

Kimathi was wounded and captured near Nyeri on **21 October 1956** by a tribal policeman, Ndirangu Mau. He was tried, hanged at Kamiti Prison on **18 February 1957** and buried in an unmarked grave inside the prison. Organised forest resistance was effectively over, although small groups held out for years.

KEY TERMS

Kenya Land and Freedom Army	The fighters' own name for their forces.
Pseudo-gang	A unit of "turned" ex-fighters, led by officers, disguised as Mau Mau to hunt them.
King's African Rifles	The British army regiment recruited from East Africans.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Which forest was led by Kimathi, and which by General China?
2. Give three reasons why the forest fighters were defeated by 1956.

CHAPTER 6 · THE OTHER WAR

A war among the Kikuyu



PHOTOGRAPH: Armed men rest in the bush during the Emergency. Much of the fighting on the government side was done by African soldiers of the King's African Rifles and by the Kikuyu Home Guard, not by British troops.

An honest account has to say clearly that Mau Mau was also a **civil war**. Most of the civilians the movement killed were not Europeans but Africans: chiefs, headmen, Home Guards, Christians who refused the oath, and neighbours accused of being informers. Only **32 European settlers** were killed during the whole Emergency. Settlers lived in fear, and some killings shocked the world, such as the murder of the Ruck family, including their six-year-old son, in January 1953. But most of the daily violence was Kikuyu against Kikuyu.

The **loyalist** side was real and organised. The **Kikuyu Home Guard**, raised by the government, guarded villages, ran screening, and fought the forest fighters, often with personal knowledge of the enemy that no British officer had. People became loyalists for many reasons: Christian faith, positions as chiefs, land they wanted to protect, fear, or anger at Mau Mau violence. Some loyalists were themselves guilty of serious abuses against suspects. Loyalist families also paid a heavy price.

The worst single event came at **Lari** on the night of **26 March 1953**. Mau Mau fighters attacked the homes of the loyalist chief Luka Wakahangara and his supporters, killing about 74 to 97 people, many of them women and children, many burned in their homes. On the same night, another Mau Mau group raided the police station at **Naivasha**, freed prisoners and took weapons. In the days after Lari, government forces and Home Guards carried out revenge killings that may have killed even more people than the massacre itself. Lari hardened opinion on all sides. In Britain it was used to portray the whole movement as savage. In the reserves, the reprisals drove more people to the forest.

Two truths at once: Mau Mau was a genuine struggle for land and freedom, and it also committed atrocities against its own people. Holding both facts together is why the memory of Mau Mau in Kenya has always been argued over and never simple.

KEY TERMS

Civil war	A war fought between groups within the same country or community.
Loyalist	An African who supported the colonial government against Mau Mau.
Home Guard	African militia raised by the government to fight Mau Mau.
Reprisal	A revenge attack carried out in response to an earlier attack.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Who were the main victims of Mau Mau violence? Why might this surprise people?
2. How was the Lari massacre used by different sides?

CHAPTER 7 · HOW BRITAIN WON

Villages, camps and the Pipeline



PHOTOGRAPH: Detainees sit behind barbed wire at a camp during the Emergency. Tens of thousands of Kikuyu were held without trial in a system the government called the Pipeline.

Britain's answer was to control the whole civilian population. On **24 April 1954**, **Operation Anvil** sealed off Nairobi and screened its entire African population. Tens of thousands were arrested and sent to camps, and many others were sent back to the reserves. Across central Kenya, more than a million Kikuyu, Embu and Meru people were forced to leave their scattered homesteads and move into about **800 fortified villages**, surrounded by ditches and barbed wire, under curfew and guarded by the Home Guard. This was called **villagisation**. It cut the supply line to the forest, but it also brought hunger, disease and suffering to many people who had never taken an oath. People were also made to do long hours of unpaid "communal labour".

People who were arrested entered the **Pipeline**, a chain of detention camps such as Manyani, Mackinnon Road, the Mwea camps, Athi River, Kamiti (for women) and Hola. Detainees were sorted by colour code: "white" (cooperative), "grey" or "black" (hard-core). They were questioned, made to work, and pressed to confess and give up the oath before moving step by step towards release. Screening teams used beatings and torture. At the hardest end were camps such as Hola, for men the authorities called "irreconcilable". Officially, about 80,000 people were detained at the peak of the system. The total number who passed through it is still disputed by historians, and it was certainly higher.

For decades the worst of this was hidden. In 2009 four elderly Kenyans, Ndiku Mutua, Paulo Nzili, Wambugu wa Nyingi and Jane Muthoni Mara, sued the British government for torture they had suffered in the camps. In 2011 the case forced the government to admit it had secretly kept thousands of colonial files, removed from Kenya before independence, at **Hanslope Park** in England. These "migrated archives" confirmed that abuse was systematic and known to senior officials. In 2012 the High Court ruled that the case could go to trial.

In **June 2013** Britain settled. It paid **£19.9 million** to **5,228** Kenyan claimants, agreed to fund a memorial in Nairobi, and the Foreign Secretary, William Hague, told Parliament that Britain recognised that Kenyans had been tortured and ill-treated by the colonial administration and "sincerely regrets that these abuses took place". The memorial was unveiled in Uhuru Park, Nairobi, in 2015.

KEY TERMS

Villagisation	Forcing rural people into guarded villages to cut off support for fighters.
Detention without trial	Holding people in custody without charging or trying them in court.
The Pipeline	The system of camps that detainees moved through before release.
Migrated archives	Colonial files secretly taken to Britain at independence.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. How did villagisation help Britain win, and what did it cost ordinary people?
2. Why was the discovery of the Hanslope Park files so important?

CHAPTER 8 · 1954–1960 · REFORM FROM ABOVE NEW CHAPTER

Land reform and the first African elections

Britain did not rely on force alone. While the war went on, it introduced reforms meant to build a class of Africans with a stake in the colonial order, and to draw support away from Mau Mau.

The Swynnerton Plan, 1954

The **Swynnerton Plan**, named after the agriculture official Roger Swynnerton, changed farming in central Kenya. Scattered strips of land were combined into single farms (**land consolidation**), and owners received individual **title deeds**. For the first time Africans were encouraged to grow valuable cash crops such as **coffee and tea**. Many African farmers did become better off. But consolidation happened while tens of thousands of men were in detention or the forest. Loyalists, who sat on the land committees, often gained the best land, while detainees' families often lost theirs. As a result, the plan created a new land divide *among* Africans that lasted long after independence.

Slow political change

In 1954 the **Lyttelton Constitution** brought the first African minister into government, B. A. Ohanga. African political parties were allowed again from 1955, but only at district level, and Kikuyu, Embu and Meru people were largely excluded. In **1957** Africans elected members to the Legislative Council for the first time: eight seats, with a limited franchise. Those elected included **Tom Mboya**, **Oginga Odinga**, **Ronald Ngala**, **Daniel arap Moi** and **Masinde Muliro**. They immediately demanded more seats, Kenyatta's release and an end to the Emergency.

The rising cost

The Emergency cost Britain roughly £55 million, a very large sum for a small colony, and tied down troops needed elsewhere. Across Africa, colonies were moving towards independence: Ghana became independent in 1957. In Britain more people were asking whether keeping a settler-dominated Kenya was worth the price.

> **Think about it:** the Swynnerton Plan is a good example of a policy with mixed results. It increased African wealth and farming output, but it also rewarded loyalists and deepened inequality over land. Historians use it to show that "winning hearts and minds" could also mean shaping who would hold power later.

KEY TERMS

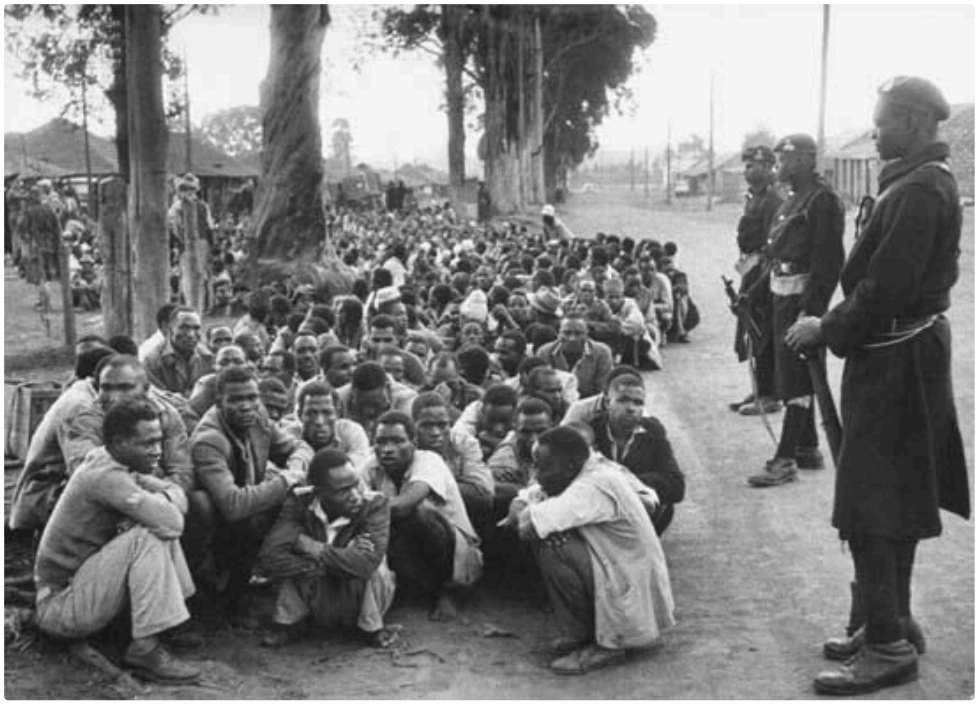
Land consolidation	Combining scattered plots into single, larger farms.
Title deed	A legal document proving individual ownership of land.
Franchise	The right to vote in elections.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Who benefited most from the Swynnerton Plan, and who lost out?
2. Name three Africans elected to LegCo in 1957.

CHAPTER 9 · 1959–1960

Hola breaks the story in Britain



PHOTOGRAPH: A crowd of Kikuyu men seated on the ground under guard during a screening operation. By the late 1950s, pictures and reports like these were reaching Britain and turning opinion against the Emergency.

On **3 March 1959**, at **Hola** detention camp near the Tana River, guards beat about 85 detainees who had refused to do forced labour. **Eleven men died**, and dozens more were seriously injured. The camp authorities first claimed the men had died from drinking contaminated water. A coroner's inquest found the truth: they had died from violence, beaten with clubs and batons. No one was ever convicted for their deaths, but the cover story collapsed in public.

Hola happened when Britain was already uneasy about Kenya. MPs such as **Barbara Castle** and Fenner Brockway had raised abuses in the camps for years and been dismissed. Now an official inquest had confirmed the worst. In the House of Commons debate in July 1959, the Conservative MP **Enoch Powell**, who was no opponent of empire, told his own party that Britain could not use one standard of behaviour in Africa and another at home:

> *"We cannot say, 'We will have African standards in Africa, Asian standards in Asia and perhaps British standards here at home.'"*

Political change followed quickly. In October 1959 **Iain Macleod** became Colonial Secretary and moved to end the Emergency and open constitutional talks. The Emergency formally ended on **12 January 1960**, and the detention camps emptied. At the first **Lancaster House Conference** in London (January–February 1960), Britain agreed that Africans would have a majority of seats in the Legislative Council. In February 1960 the Prime Minister, Harold Macmillan, spoke in South Africa of a "wind of change" blowing through Africa. The ban on national African parties was lifted, and two new parties formed in 1960: **KANU** (Kenya African National Union), led by politicians such as Mboya and Odinga, and **KADU** (Kenya African Democratic Union), led by Ngala, which represented smaller communities afraid of Kikuyu and Luo dominance. KANU demanded what had been unthinkable in 1952: a date for independence, and Kenyatta's release.

> **Why Hola mattered:** Mau Mau had lost the forest war years earlier. Hola showed that the system built to win it could no longer be defended in Britain itself, and a government ashamed of a war is under pressure to end it.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. What was Powell's main argument about Hola? Why was it significant that a Conservative made it?
2. What was the difference between KANU and KADU?

CHAPTER 10 · 1960–1964 · UHURU

The road to independence



ILLUSTRATION: Painting made for this document; an artist's impression. Independence night, Nairobi, 12 December 1963: the Kenyan flag rises before a vast crowd. Photographs of the midnight ceremony are dark and unclear, so the moment is painted here and labelled as such.

Kenyatta's release became the test of every negotiation. KANU won the most votes in the February 1961 elections but refused to form a government while he was still held. KADU formed a government instead. In **August 1961**, after nearly nine years in prison and restriction, Kenyatta was freed. The man convicted at Kapenguria as Mau Mau's manager was now clearly Kenya's leader-in-waiting, and he soon became president of KANU.

At the second Lancaster House Conference in 1962, KANU pressed for a strong central government with majority rule. KADU and settler groups argued for safeguards, including a regional system called ***majimbo*** that gave powers to regions. The settlers' old hope of a permanently white-led Kenya was finished. To ease the change, Britain funded the **Million-Acre Scheme** (from 1962), which bought land from departing European settlers and resettled African families on it. Land was bought back, not simply returned, and much of it went to those who could pay.

KANU won the **May 1963** elections decisively. On **1 June 1963** Kenya gained internal self-government (**Madaraka**), with Kenyatta as prime minister. At midnight on **12 December 1963**, at a ground on the edge of Nairobi now called **Uhuru Gardens**, the British Union Jack was lowered and Kenya's black, red, green and white flag was raised for the first time. Prince Philip, Duke of Edinburgh, represented the Queen. *Uhuru* means "freedom" in Kiswahili.

Kenyatta's government chose reconciliation. Former loyalists and former forest fighters were told to forgive and work together under the slogan ***harambee***, "let us all pull together". This also meant that Mau Mau was not celebrated, and that many loyalists kept the land and positions they had gained. On 12 December 1964 Kenya became a **republic**, with Kenyatta as its first president. KADU dissolved itself and joined KANU the same year.

> **Assessing the outcome:** Mau Mau did not win its war. But without the rebellion, and without the cost in money, soldiers and reputation of defeating it, it is hard to believe Britain would have handed over Kenya in 1963, or handed it to Kenyatta.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Why did African politicians refuse to govern until Kenyatta was released?
2. What is the difference between Madaraka Day (1 June 1963) and Independence Day (12 December 1963)?

CHAPTER 11 · MEMORY

Memory, apology and the land that stayed divided



PHOTOGRAPH: The statue of Dedan Kimathi on Kimathi Street, Nairobi, unveiled on 18 February 2007, fifty years after his execution. For most of that time Mau Mau was still officially a banned organisation in independent Kenya.

Independent Kenya did not at first honour Mau Mau. Kenyatta wanted to unite the country and reassure settlers and investors, and he is often quoted as saying that Mau Mau was "a disease which had been eradicated, and must never be remembered again". The colonial ban on the movement stayed in force until **2003**, when President Mwai Kibaki's government lifted it. Many veterans lived and died poor. They watched the former White Highlands pass, through purchase schemes, to a new African elite as often as to the landless. The land question was eased, but never solved, and it remains a source of political tension in Kenya today.

Recognition came slowly. Kimathi's statue was put up in central Nairobi in 2007. The **2010 Constitution** turned 20 October, formerly Kenyatta Day, into **Mashujaa Day** (Heroes' Day), honouring all who fought for freedom. Kimathi's widow, **Mukami Kimathi**, campaigned until her death in 2023 for his remains to be found in Kamiti Prison and given a proper burial. His grave has still not been publicly identified.

The 2013 settlement was won by elderly veterans in a London court. It led other former colonies to ask what files Britain still held about them. However, a larger case brought by about 40,000 Kenyans was dismissed by the High Court in 2018, mainly because so much time had passed that a fair trial was no longer possible. During a state visit to Kenya in **October–November 2023**, **King Charles III** said that the "abhorrent and unjustifiable acts of violence" committed against Kenyans during the struggle for independence were "a source of the greatest sorrow and the deepest regret". Many Kenyans welcomed this, but others noted that it was not a full apology and included no new compensation.

Mau Mau has also shaped Kenyan literature. Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's novels *Weep Not, Child* (1964) and *A Grain of Wheat* (1967), and the play *The Trial of Dedan Kimathi* (1976) by Ngũgĩ and Micere Mugo, are widely studied in schools.

> **Conclusion:** historians still argue about the numbers, and Kenyans still argue about who the rebellion belonged to. What is not disputed is the direction it forced: after Mau Mau, settler rule in Kenya had no future.

CHECK YOUR UNDERSTANDING

1. Why did Kenya's first government avoid celebrating Mau Mau?
2. List three ways Mau Mau has been recognised since 2003.

REFERENCE · 1 NEW

Key people

PERSON	WHO THEY WERE
Jomo Kenyatta	KCA activist and KAU president; convicted at Kapenguria (1953); released 1961; Kenya's first prime minister (1963) and president (1964–1978).
Dedan Kimathi	Leader of the Aberdare forest fighters and head of the Kenya Defence Council; captured October 1956, hanged February 1957.
Waruhiu Itote ("General China")	Ex-soldier who served in Burma; Mau Mau commander on Mount Kenya; captured January 1954.
Stanley Mathenge	Aberdare forest leader and rival of Kimathi; disappeared, fate unknown.
Muthoni wa Kirima	Woman fighter who reached the rank of field marshal; left the forest after independence.
Harry Thuku	Early protest leader; his arrest led to the 1922 Nairobi shooting.
Mary Muthoni Nyanjiru	Woman who led the crowd at the 1922 protest and was shot dead.
Fred Kubai & Makhan Singh	Trade union leaders in Nairobi; Kubai was one of the Kapenguria Six.
Kapenguria Six	Kenyatta, Bildad Kaggia, Fred Kubai, Kung'u Karumba, Paul Ngei, Achieng' Oneko.
Senior Chief Waruhiu	Loyalist chief killed 7 October 1952, shortly before the Emergency was declared.
Sir Evelyn Baring	Governor of Kenya, 1952–1959; declared the Emergency.
Gen. Sir George Erskine	British commander in Kenya, 1953–1955.
Barbara Castle & Enoch Powell	British MPs from opposite parties who condemned the abuses, especially after Hola.
Iain Macleod	Colonial Secretary from 1959; ended the Emergency and began the move to majority rule.
Tom Mboya, Oginga Odinga, Ronald Ngala	African politicians elected in 1957 who led the campaign for independence (Mboya and Odinga in KANU, Ngala in KADU).
Mukami Kimathi	Dedan Kimathi's widow and a campaigner for veterans until her death in 2023.

Glossary

Askari: African soldier or policeman in colonial service.

Batuni oath: the "platoon" oath taken by fighters.

Detainee: a person held without trial.

Emergency: the period 1952–1960 when special powers were in force.

Harambee: "let us all pull together"; Kenyatta's slogan for national unity.

Ithaka na wiyathi: "land and freedom" (Kikuyu).

Kipande: compulsory pass for African men.

Loyalist: an African who supported the government against Mau Mau.

Madaraka: self-rule; Madaraka Day is 1 June.

Majimbo: a regional (federal) system of government.

Mashujaa: heroes; Mashujaa Day is 20 October.

Panga: a machete used for farm work.

Passive wing: civilian supporters of the fighters.

Pipeline: the system of detention camps.

Screening: mass questioning of suspects.

Shamba: a farm or plot of land.

Squatter: an African resident labourer on a settler farm.

Uhuru: freedom or independence (Kiswahili).

Villagisation: forced resettlement into guarded villages.

White Highlands: highland farmland reserved for Europeans.

REFERENCE · 2 NEW

The human cost: what the numbers say

Figures for the Emergency are uncertain. Official British figures were collected by the side doing much of the killing and detaining, and many deaths were never recorded. The table below gives commonly cited figures. Treat them as approximate.

GROUP	FIGURE	NOTES
Mau Mau fighters and suspects killed by security forces	about 11,000 (official)	Historian David Anderson estimates more than 20,000.
African civilians killed by Mau Mau	about 1,800	Mostly loyalists, chiefs, Christians and suspected informers.
Members of the security forces killed	about 170–200	Including 63 Europeans; most were African.
European civilians killed	32	Far fewer than the fear among settlers suggested.
Asian civilians killed	26	
People hanged for Emergency offences	1,090	Highest in any British colonial emergency.
People held in detention	about 80,000 at the peak (official)	The total who passed through the camps was much higher; some estimates exceed 150,000.
People moved into guarded villages	over 1 million	In about 800 villages, 1954–1955.

What historians still debate

1. What was Mau Mau? Some see it mainly as a *nationalist* movement for the whole of Kenya. Others stress that it was mostly a *Kikuyu*, Embu and Meru movement driven by land and by divisions within Kikuyu society, a civil war as much as an anti-colonial war. Most historians today accept that it was both.

2. How many died? Caroline Elkins (*Britain's Gulag* / *Imperial Reckoning*, 2005) argued that the detention system was far larger and deadlier than admitted, and suggested very high numbers of missing Kikuyu. Her highest population estimates are disputed by other historians, but the 2011 archive discoveries confirmed her central claim that abuse was widespread and systematic.

3. Who won? Militarily, Britain. Politically, many argue Mau Mau did, because the rebellion made settler rule impossible. Others point out that the people who gained most from independence were often loyalists and educated politicians, not the forest fighters.

4. Where did the name come from? Explanations include a mishearing of Kikuyu words, a children's word game, or an invention by the colonial authorities. No explanation has been proven.

> **Study skill:** when you read any source on Mau Mau, ask who produced it, when, and why. Colonial reports, settler memoirs, fighters' memoirs and later court evidence all have different purposes and blind spots.

REFERENCE · 3

Key dates (expanded)

1895	East Africa Protectorate declared; Uganda Railway built soon after.
1902	Crown Lands Ordinance lets the government grant land to settlers.
1915	Crown Lands Ordinance makes all land Crown land; Native Registration Ordinance creates the kipande.
1920	Kenya becomes a Crown Colony; kipande enforced.
Mar 1922	Harry Thuku arrested; police fire on protesters in Nairobi.
1924–25	Kikuyu Central Association formed.
1929	Kenyatta goes to London; circumcision controversy leads to independent schools.
1932–34	Carter Land Commission rejects most African land claims.
1940	KCA banned; its leaders detained.
1944	Kenya African Study Union founded (renamed KAU in 1946).
1946–47	Kenyatta returns to Kenya (1946) and becomes KAU president (1947).
1950	Nairobi general strike; Mau Mau banned (August).
7 Oct 1952	Senior Chief Waruhiu assassinated.
20 Oct 1952	State of Emergency declared; Operation Jock Scott arrests Kenyatta and others.
Jan 1953	Ruck family killed.
26 Mar 1953	Lari massacre and Naivasha police station raid.
Apr 1953	Kapenguria Six convicted; KAU banned in June.
Jun 1953	General Erskine takes command.
Jan 1954	General China captured.
Apr 1954	Operation Anvil in Nairobi; villagisation and mass detention follow. Swynnerton Plan launched.
21 Oct 1956	Dedan Kimathi captured.
18 Feb 1957	Kimathi hanged at Kamiti Prison.
Mar 1957	First African elections to the Legislative Council.
3 Mar 1959	Hola massacre: 11 detainees beaten to death.
12 Jan 1960	Emergency ends; first Lancaster House Conference follows.
1960	KANU and KADU formed.
Aug 1961	Kenyatta released.
1 Jun 1963	Madaraka: internal self-government, Kenyatta prime minister.
12 Dec 1963	Independence (Uhuru).
12 Dec 1964	Kenya becomes a republic; Kenyatta president.
2003	Ban on Mau Mau lifted.
2007	Kimathi statue unveiled in Nairobi.
2010	New constitution creates Mashujaa Day (20 October).
2011–13	Hanslope Park files revealed; Britain settles the veterans' case (June 2013).
2015	British-funded Mau Mau memorial unveiled in Uhuru Park, Nairobi.
2018	Larger claim by about 40,000 Kenyans dismissed in the High Court.
Oct 2023	King Charles III expresses "the greatest sorrow and the deepest regret" in Nairobi.

REFERENCE · 4 NEW

Review and essay questions

Short-answer questions

1. What did the fighters call themselves, and what did *ithaka na wiyathi* mean?
2. Give two ways colonial rule controlled the daily lives of Africans before 1952.
3. What happened on 20 October 1952, and why is that date a public holiday today?
4. Who were the Kapenguria Six?
5. What was Operation Anvil?
6. What happened at Hola in March 1959?
7. What did Britain agree to in the 2013 settlement?

Explain and analyse

8. "Land was the cause of everything." How far do you agree? Consider land, labour, politics and culture.
9. Explain why Mau Mau can be described as both an anti-colonial war and a civil war.
10. Why was Britain able to defeat the forest fighters by 1956?
11. Explain how events in Britain, especially Hola, helped bring about Kenyan independence.
12. "Mau Mau lost the war but won the peace." Assess this view.
13. Why has the memory of Mau Mau been so contested in independent Kenya?

Source skills

14. Look at the photograph in Chapter 4. What does it tell us about screening, and what can it *not* tell us?
15. Why might a colonial government report and a former detainee's memoir describe the same camp differently? How would a historian use both?

Further reading

Histories: David Anderson, *Histories of the Hanged* (2005); Caroline Elkins, *Britain's Gulag* (US title *Imperial Reckoning*, 2005); Daniel Branch, *Defeating Mau Mau, Creating Kenya* (2009); Tabitha Kanogo, *Squatters and the Roots of Mau Mau* (1987); Cora Ann Presley, *Kikuyu Women, the Mau Mau Rebellion and Social Change in Kenya* (1992).

Memoirs by participants: Waruhiu Itote, *"Mau Mau" General* (1967); J. M. Kariuki, *"Mau Mau" Detainee* (1963); Donald Barnett and Karari Njama, *Mau Mau from Within* (1966).

Literature: Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, *Weep Not, Child* (1964) and *A Grain of Wheat* (1967); Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o and Micere Mugo, *The Trial of Dedan Kimathi* (1976).

Sources: the Hola inquest findings; the Kapenguria trial record; the Mutua & Others v. Foreign and Commonwealth Office litigation and the Hanslope Park "migrated archives"; the UK Foreign Secretary's statement of 6 June 2013; King Charles III's state banquet speech in Nairobi, October 2023; and the histories listed above. Elkins's highest estimates of deaths remain debated among historians.